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Presidential Telephone Calls - Memorandum of Conversations 1/1/91 - 1/28/91

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THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON

0038

MEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telecon with Prime Minister Major of Britain

PARTICIPANTS: The President
Prime Minister Major
Note Taker: Richard Haass

DATE, TIME January 3, 1991, 5:30 - 5:39am EST
AND PLACE The Oval Office

The President telephoned Prime Minister Major concerning the proposed visit of Secretary Baker and Iraqi Foreign Minister Aziz in Switzerland.

After complimentary greetings, President Bush stated that he wished to confirm that Prime Minister Major was aware that Secretary Baker would be traveling to Europe and the Gulf to consult with coalition allies. President Bush said that his proposal to Iraq expired 3 January and that he would announce a new offer to Iraq that Secretary Baker meet with Iraqi Foreign Minister Aziz in Switzerland between January 7 and 9. President Bush stated that this meeting would be going the "extra mile for peace" and would serve to remove any criticism that the U.S. was not doing enough to find a diplomatic solution to the Gulf Crisis.

President Bush then stated that he has not changed his thinking one iota and wished to reiterate that this meeting would not be to negotiate or make deals or compromises. There are no behind the scenes maneuvers. The President wanted the Prime Minister "to hear it from me" and hoped that this meeting would meet with the Prime Minister's approval.

Prime Minister Major said that this meeting was "right" and he accepts that there is no change in President Bush's thinking. He added that this offer will make the Friday EC meeting easier for British Foreign Minister Douglas Hurd and that this public presentation is just what we want.

President Bush then stated that he is disinclined to accept any further meetings if the Iraqis accept the Baker and Aziz meeting.

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The President stated we have tried and that Saddam has met with every rag tag: Connelly, Muhammed Ali. . .this is it." He solicited Prime Minister Major's views on this subject.

The Prime Minister stated that he shared the President's view that a meeting in Switzerland between Baker and Aziz would be sufficient and sees no need for a subsequent meeting. The President again stated that he did not see the need and that there were all kinds of outside initiatives. Benjidad had one and King Hussein also.

The President asked if the Prime Minister had met yet with Jordanian King Hussein. The Prime Minister replied that he would have lunch with him today and speculated that the King would have "an initiative in his back pocket." President Bush replied that it was his opinion that any such initiative would contain nothing new. Prime Minister Major agreed, but stated that he would listen and would give the President a read-out of the meeting shortly after its conclusion either by telephone or special message. The President then stated Hussein is a good little man and requested Prime Minister Major express to King Hussein that President Bush's personal relationship goes back many years and that he sympathizes with King Hussein's tough spot. The President stated that King Hussein would like to hear of his distress at the new tensions between the United States and Jordan. The Prime Minister replied that he would be happy to convey this.

In closing, the President reiterated that nothing has changed in his thinking and expressed his hope that events would occur sooner rather than later. The President promised to keep the Prime Minister informed of any developments.

-- End of Conversation --

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